TOPIC 1 · FUNDAMENTALS OF MICROSOFT 365 COPILOT
LAB 1 THEME · EXCEL TO WORD

Lab 1 — Prepare Work Orders and Draft the Operations Brief

Maps to	LO1: integrate verified Word, Excel, PowerPoint and Outlook outputs
Duration	30 minutes
Tools	Microsoft 365 Copilot · Excel · Word · PowerPoint · Outlook
Mock data	data/Northstar_Work_Orders.xlsx
Course	GenAI for Engineers · v2.4
Prompts	https://tertiarycourses.github.io/IES-GenAI-for-Engineers/prompts/#lab-1

Goal

You are the maintenance coordinator at Northstar Water Services, a fictional water-pipe maintenance company. Clean a messy work-order export with Copilot in Excel, add check formulas, then turn the clean data into a one-page Word brief.

What You Will Build

A clean Northstar_Work_Orders.xlsx (120 rows and a Checks sheet) and Northstar_Operations_Brief.docx.

Prerequisites

- Microsoft 365 account with Copilot available in Word, Excel, PowerPoint and Outlook. Availability depends on the assigned licence and tenant settings; confirm access with the trainer before class.
- Desktop Excel on Windows or Mac. Download this lab folder and open the files straight from its data folder; save any new file in the same folder. All data is fictional.

Data note

Northstar Water Services is a fictional water-pipe maintenance and service company. All service hubs, staff and work orders are synthetic. Use the fixed reporting date 2026-09-30; missing facts remain UNKNOWN. Proposals do not change real assignments. Training email drafts are never sent.

Steps

Step 1. Look at the data. Open data/Northstar_Work_Orders.xlsx in Excel and open Copilot from the Copilot button on the Home tab. Choose Chat only (answers, no changes) and send the prompt. Copilot should find 122 rows, 2 repeated IDs (WO-2026-0005 and WO-2026-0020) and 2 job categories spelt differently.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
EXCEL - CHAT ONLY:
Describe this work-order table for me. How many rows are there? Are there any repeated
Work_Order_IDs, or Job_Category names spelt in different ways? Don't change anything.
```

Step 2. Clean the table. Switch to Allow editing and send the prompt. Select Done to keep the change, or Undo to reverse it. The table should now have 120 rows and 5 job categories.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
EXCEL - ALLOW EDITING:
Copy the table to a new sheet named Raw_Export. Then remove the repeated rows, keeping one row
for each Work_Order_ID, and fix the Job_Category spelling. Leave empty Assigned_To cells
empty.
```

Step 3. Add check formulas. Send the prompt and select Done. You should see 120 total, 48 closed, 12 cancelled, 60 backlog, 50 overdue, 6 unassigned, cost S$35,827.50. Save the workbook (Ctrl+S / Cmd+S).

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
EXCEL - ALLOW EDITING:
In the Checks sheet, add formulas that count the total work orders, closed, cancelled, backlog
(not Closed or Cancelled), overdue backlog (due before the date in Control!B2) and unassigned
backlog, and add up Cost_SGD.
```

Step 4. Write the brief in Word. Open data/templates/Northstar_Operations_Brief_Template.docx in Word and save it as Northstar_Operations_Brief.docx. In Copilot select + > Upload images and files and choose Northstar_Work_Orders.xlsx from this lab's data folder, then send the prompt.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
WORD COPILOT:
Write a one-page operations brief in this document from the uploaded
Northstar_Work_Orders.xlsx. Include the reporting date, the key numbers from the Checks sheet,
the backlog and overdue findings, the unassigned jobs, proposed next actions and open
questions. Use only numbers from the workbook, and write UNKNOWN for anything it does not
show.
```

Step 5. Check the brief. Send the prompt in the same chat and fix any number it lists. Save the brief.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
WORD COPILOT:
Check every number in this brief against the uploaded workbook. List any number that is
different, with the correct value.
```

Copy buttons for every prompt: https://tertiarycourses.github.io/IES-GenAI-for-Engineers/prompts/#lab-1

Test It

Check	Expected result
Clean table	120 rows, one per Work_Order_ID; 5 job categories.
Checks	120 total, 48 closed, 12 cancelled, 60 backlog, 50 overdue, 6 unassigned, cost S$35,827.50.
Word brief	Same numbers as the Checks sheet; empty owners left empty.

Troubleshooting

If this happens	Fix
Copilot cannot see my file	In Excel, save the file and open Copilot again. In Word, PowerPoint or Outlook, upload the file with + > Upload images and files, and upload it again after you change it.
A number is different from the lab	Clear any slicers or filters, check the table has no extra rows, then ask again in a new chat.
A button or feature is missing	Check you are signed in with your course account and Microsoft 365 is up to date, then tell your trainer.

Challenge

Repeat the task for one different site and explain how the filter scope changes the result. Keep the original verified output.

Reflection

Which evidence proves the output is correct, and which decision still needs a person?